

## THANK YOU

Demo Recording 2023

Erick Carter Benzene ☼ Carla Angeline Mongado Vinyl

The Tank 2025

Caitlin Mayernik Producer ☼ Aliyah Curry Director ☼ Grace Shih Music Dir.  
 Matthew Ramirez Stage Manager ☼ Fang Tseng Choreographer ☼ My Le Lighting Des.  
 Melinda Faylor Sound ☼ Gianna Nepola Costume ☼ Kimi Handa Brown Intimacy  
 Erick Carter Benzene ☼ Kammy Wong Vinyl ☼ Mx Hasberry Hydroxyl  
 ☼ Joshua Erickson Piano ☼ Tommy Ong Cello ☼ Emerson Cyrus Olson Violin

Underground Skills Exchange 2025

Riley Payne Director ☼ Willow Lautenberg Benzene ☼ Kammy Wong Vinyl  
 Joshua Erickson Piano

## DAVID QUANG PHAM (he★they)

David Quang Pham is an award-winning composer-playwright and science communicator in Washington Heights, who was awarded a televised front-row seat at the 78th Tony Awards. His musicals include *Ellipses* and *Turnover: A New Leaf*, one acts *Life After* with Marie Incontrera and Stephanie L. Carlin and *Check Out* with Eric Grunin and Valerie Work. David's plays have been produced or developed by *Queer Theatre Kalamazoo*, Musical Theatre Factory, The Tank, Milky Way Theatre Company, Theatre 71, Signature Theatre, New York Public Library, and The Workshop Theater (*The Living Fossils*). His musicals have been staged in Colorado, Georgia, Michigan, and Portugal. He also aspires to be an animation screenwriter, having studied under David N Weiss and Kim Barranté at Sundance Collab. They readapted *Ellipses* and *Turnover* into the animated features, *The Galaxy Family* and *Photosynthesis*. He was the 2024 Great Performances Artist Fellowship Award recipient, 2022 Harriet Tubman Effect Institute composer, 2021 Playwrights Foundation fellow, and 2020 Working Title Playwrights apprentice. His pentatonic music composition blends pop, punk, and Vietnamese folk to create melodies that reflect his Eastern influences. They are under the mentorship of composers *Janelle Lawrence* and *Gonzalo Valencia-Peña*. When not writing songs full of science puns, David plays trombone for Queer Big Apple Corps, Marching Band Casting, and Vietnamese zither with *Mekong NYC*. They hold a B.S. in Astrophysics with honors and minor in theatre from Michigan State University. Be up to lightspeed at [@sciencetheatre](https://www.sciencetheatre.us) or [www.sciencetheatre.us](http://www.sciencetheatre.us)

## PLOT SUMMARY

*Chemicals in the Water* is a romantic dark comedy musical where two vagabonds fall in love in the midst of an environmental disaster. This story follows Benzene, a sweet Forest Fire Magazines editor, and Vinyl, a hot-headed songwriter. When their train derails in a river, Benzene and Vinyl must form a toxic relationship in order to survive Mother Nature's wrath.

An eastbound train contains a couple Michiganders: Benzene, an editor needing a break from Midland, and Vinyl, a songwriter looking for their big break in New York City. The train abruptly derails, trapping Benzene and Vinyl in Ohio ("[I Need a Break](#)").

Governor Hydroxyl declares there will be no assistance for the derailment ("[No Agency](#)"). Benzene and Vinyl try to exit the train, only to find they are submerged in the Ohio River. They learn about one another through astrology ("[What's Your Sign?](#)").

Soon, a boat floats by. They take a chance at it. As they paddle with their hands, rainbows emerge out of the water. It turns into a date ("[Chemicals in the Water](#)"). Soon, a bunch of frogs jump them, capsizing the boat.

When Benzene and Vinyl resurface, they face Mother Nature. Mother Nature supposedly leads them to a manmade path out of Ohio. Instead, it is a trap and Mother Nature sends their animalistic goons after them. They fight back the foxes but run off when the eagle is deployed ("[Kick Mother Nature In](#)").

They hide away in Calcutta, seemingly a ghost town. As Vinyl brings in Benzene for a dance, the town folks get out onto the streets. The Chemicals' dance has had a negative effect on them ("[A Toxic Relationship](#)"). They direct Benzene and Vinyl out of Ohio towards the bridge in the east.

They reach the bridge to Pennsylvania. As they cross in the fog, Mother Nature's eagle pushes Benzene off the bridge, mortally wounding them ("[I See Myself With You](#)").

Instead of striking a chord, Vinyl strikes a match and sets the wildlife alight. They comfort Benzene by declaring that love's in the air and that they will be seen ("[Airborne](#)").

Adapting the 2023 Ohio train derailment into a romantic dark comedy, physicist-turned-dramatist and Michigander David Quang Pham interrogates the lack of environmental regulations, city air quality, local/state government redlining, and even Mother Nature with his musical, *Chemicals in the Water*.

## CAST OF CHARACTERS

**BENZENE**, adult, a nature magazine editor of DOW's Forest Fire Magazines from Midland, Michigan. They are a cancer (astrology). Reactive, nature-loving, sweet, and toxic.

**VINYL**, adult, a PVC guitar-wielding songwriter from Detroit, Michigan. They are a cancer (personality). Reactive, nature-hating, heated, and toxic.

**CONDUCTOR**, adult, the train conductor (voice only) ///

GOVERNOR **HYDROXYL**, adult, the Governor of Ohio (voice only) ///

**MOTHER NATURE**, adult, the mother of Nature (voice only)

Optional

**PARSLEY** & **PYRUS**, characters from David Quang Pham's plant-based musical *Turnover: A New Leaf*, who are now literal plants, singing "**Photosynthesis**" in the wilderness setting (voice only)

☼ Androgyny Chemistry: Each character resembles the androgynous nature, with open-ended vocal requirements

☼ Queer People of the Global Majority most represent the experiences of these chemicals; cast accordingly

## MUSICAL NUMBERS

1. "**I Need a Break**" Benzene, Vinyl, Conductor
2. "**No Agency (No Further Assistance Needed)**" Hydroxyl, Benzene, Vinyl
3. "**What's Your Sign?**" Benzene, Vinyl
4. "**Chemicals in the Water**" Benzene, Vinyl
5. "**Kick Mother Nature In**" Benzene, Vinyl, Mother Nature
6. "**A Toxic Relationship**" Benzene, Vinyl
7. "**I See Myself With You**" Benzene, Vinyl
8. "**Airborne (Love's in the Air)**" Benzene, Vinyl, Mother Nature